

KEEPING IT REAL

TRUST IN AI FOR HOME SEARCH JUST COLLAPSED.

30% to 16%, in one year. Here's what buyers want instead.

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**55% OF BUYERS
NOW SAY THEY
WANT A HUMAN
FOR THE BIGGEST
FINANCIAL
DECISION THEY'LL
MAKE.**

Cotality's 2026 global homebuyer survey. The AI hype cycle and the actual buyer are telling two different stories.

BUYERS DIDN'T LOSE TRUST IN AI. THEY LOST TRUST IN AI DOING THIS **ALONE**.

A Cotality survey found homebuyer trust in AI to help find a home fell from 30% in 2025 to 16% in 2026, a 14-point drop in a single year. At the same time, 55% of buyers said they would prefer working with a person to secure a mortgage, up from 46% the year before. Three in four buyers still assume AI is somewhere in the process. They just want a person checking its work.

WHAT THAT MEANS FOR YOUR MARKETING THIS MONTH:

1 Put your name and face on every listing description.

An auto-generated blurb is the exact thing buyers say they trust less this year.

2 Call before you text-blast.

A real check-in beats an automated drip in the same year buyers said they want a person, not a system.

3 Say out loud what you catch that AI doesn't.

The number that doesn't match the comps, the line item a buyer would gloss over. Name the specific save, not "I add value."

THE TAKEAWAY

AI DIDN'T REPLACE THE AGENT THIS YEAR.

It made the case for one. Make sure yours is the name buyers see.